Talking With Mom About Her Finances

Who should be there, how to ask and what to write down.

Mom pays her own bills and keeps her own files, and she has never needed to explain them to anyone. Asking about them can feel like prying, to both of you.

This guide is for one conversation with one job: to find out, with her permission, what there is and where it's kept. It isn't for deciding anything.

Who should be there

Mom, and whoever she wants. These are her finances, so the guest list is hers. For a first conversation that may be just the two of you at her kitchen table.

If she'd like your brother or sister there, or would rather tell them herself afterward, go with that. If several of you are in the room, pick one person to take notes, and let Mom see what's being written.

How to open

Start with why you're asking, and make it easy for her to say “not today.” The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau says that even if it feels awkward, it is important to have an honest conversation about finances, and that a person can give someone they trust an overview without sharing all the details. [1]

- “Mom, nothing's wrong and I'm not asking you to change anything. I realized that if you ever asked me to help with something, I wouldn't know where to start.”
- “You don't have to tell me amounts. I'd just like to know what there is and where the papers are kept.”
- Say what the conversation is for: knowing what exists and where to find it. Say what it isn't for: taking over, or deciding anything about her money.

What to ask her permission for

Ask for each of these separately. She may say yes to some and not to others, and that's an answer to write down, not something to talk her out of.

- To write down a list of what she has: income, accounts, insurance, property.
- To look through the paperwork with her, or simply to know where it's kept.
- To be with her when she asks her bank or insurance company a question.
- To tell one other person in the family where the list is.
- To bring the list, later on, to a professional.

Questions to ask

Ask Mom

1. Who takes care of the bills and the accounts now? Is it all you, or does anyone help?

2. What comes in each month, and where does it come from?

3. Where do you bank, and are there accounts or CDs anywhere else?

4. Besides the house, is there other property: land, a car, a share in a business, anything else you'd want on the list?

5. What insurance do you have? Is there life insurance, or a long-term care policy?

6. Where do you keep it all, and who would you want to know where it is?

Ask each other, if Mom wants the family involved

1. What does each of us already know about Mom's finances, and how do we know it?

2. Where does what one of us remembers differ from what Mom said?

How to write down what was said

Use Mom's own words where you can. Where she isn't sure, or two people remember something differently, write both and don't settle it. “Not sure” is worth writing down: it tells you what to look for next.

WHAT WAS SAID	WHO SAID IT	WHERE THE PAPERWORK IS	STILL TO CHECK
“There's the pension from the school district. It goes straight into my checking account.”	Mom	Top drawer of the hall desk	
Thinks there's an old savings account at the bank Mom used before she moved.	Denise	Hasn't turned up	Mom doesn't remember it. Ask the bank together.

What not to decide yet

These belong to a later conversation with a professional who knows your state, and your notes are what make that conversation useful. Leave them open.

- Whether anything should be moved, retitled or put in someone else's name.
- Whether a beneficiary should change.
- How much Mom has available to pay for care, or what any of this means for Medicaid.
- Who remembered it right.

What you can decide today

- Which part to start with, and when you'll sit down together next.
- Where the list will be kept for now.
- Who, if anyone, Mom wants told.
- Who will take each open question to her bank, her insurance company or a professional.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't resolve a disagreement, decide anything about Mom's accounts or property, or tell you what a professional will say. It gets what she's willing to share onto one page, in her words. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You and Mom have talked, and what she told you is on paper in her own words. The planning interview takes it from there: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Planning for diminished capacity and illness